Mikeitz 5783

The בית הלוי on the פרשה quotes the מדרש רבה on פרשת מקץ, which references a פסוק in תהילים (40:5): אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר אֲשֶׁר שָׂם ה' מִבְטַחוֹ וְלֹא פָנָה אֶל רְהָבִים זה יוסף - Praised is the man who puts his בטחון in Hashem; and he did not turn to magicians, magic, or other sources. The מדרש explains that because יוסף asked the שר המשקים to "remember me and mention me," an additional two years were added to his time in prison.

This מדרש is cited in רש"י. The בית הלוי notes that this מדרש seems difficult to understand. On the one hand, יוסף is praised for his בטחון in Hashem. On the other hand, he is criticized and punished for making a minimal effort - two simple statements to the שר המשקים. A person is allowed to make השתדלות, as the פסוק says (דברים 15:18): וּבֵרַכְךָ ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה - Hashem gives us a ברכה in all of our actions, and it also says (דברים 11:14): וְאָסַפְתָּ דְגָנֶךָ וְתִירֹשְׁךָ - you will gather your grain and wine. This implies that people must work - plant, nurture the fields, harvest - rather than sit back and passively rely on Hashem. So why is יוסף criticized for his השתדלות?

The בית הלוי offers a profound explanation. He explains that the תורה allows השתדלות because most people are not on the level to rely entirely on Hashem. However, there is an ultimate מדרגה of בטחון where a person places complete trust in Hashem, relying entirely on Him to provide everything. This was the level בני ישראל experienced in the מדבר when they were sustained by the מן without planting or harvesting.

For most people, השתדלות is allowed as part of the process of working toward greater בטחון. Every person has a different מדרגה, and his level of effort depends on where he stands. Someone on a lower מדרגה may require more השתדלות to maintain and grow his trust in Hashem. However, once someone reaches a very high מדרגה of בטחון, even minimal השתדלות can be considered excessive.

The בית הלוי that יוסף הצדיק is described as אַשְׁרֵי שָׂם מִבְטַחוֹ, someone on an extraordinary level of בטחון. Since יוסף was on such an elevated מדרגה, even his minimal השתדלות - two short statements to the שר המשקים - was considered too much. To us, this level of sensitivity seems unfathomable; most people in his situation would naturally call for help. But יוסף, due to his unique level of בטחון, was held to a higher standard. Therefore, he was punished with two additional years in prison.

We should understand the greatness of יוסף הצדיק and his מדרגה of בטחון, and also work on our own בטחון to get to such a level; הלוואי, we should come even close to that. Rabbi Oelbaum recently suggested a practical approach: make it a habit to say bezras Hashem throughout the day. For example: "I'm going to work today, bezras Hashem." "I'm getting into the car to go somewhere, bezras Hashem." "I'm traveling to the mountains for Shabbos, bezras Hashem." This small but consistent practice is a beautiful way to strengthen our בטחון. Have a wonderful Shabbos and happy Chanukah!

https://youtu.be/SXWSIbVSz3k